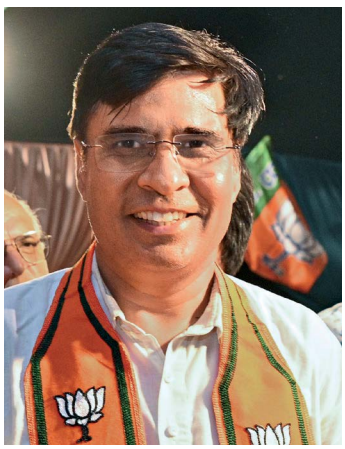
against the party's interests. The move has already triggered internal fissures, with senior leader Sukhdev Singh Dhindsa opposing it publicly. Adesh, a grandson of former CM Pratap Singh Kairon, is likely to join the BJP soon.

The Hindu Counter-narrative

Amid the radical resurgence, former Congress minister Bharat Bhushan Ashu has minced no words while raising concern over the dwindling political space for Hindus in the state. Despite the community comprising more than 45 per cent of the state's electorate, his own party has granted tickets to only two Hindus—Dharamvira Gandhi and Vijay Inder Singla, both with no clear history of having raised community-centric issues. While Ashu may harbour resentment against the Congress leadership after being overlooked for candidature from Ludhiana in favour of Raja Warring, who is a Jat Sikh, political observers believe the Hindu sentiment cannot be disregarded. Even Warring's wife Amrita has embarked on a temple run to complement her husband's outreach efforts.

Historically, Punjab's Hindus have favoured the Congress due to its clear anti-Khalistan stance. The BJP, owing to its alliance with the Akali Dal, had so far failed to inspire similar confidence within the community. However, this time, as the BJP contests independently in all 13 seats, it has fielded a diverse array of candidates—Rajput leader Dinesh Babbu from Gurdaspur, Arvind Khanna (Punjabi Khatri, Sangrur), Sushil Kumar Rinku (Ravidasi Dalit, Jalandhar) and Gejja Ram (Valmiki Hindu, Fatehgarh Sahib) among others. But the biggest surprise is the candidature of Subhash Sharma, a staunch RSS insider, from Anandpur Sahib.



ARUN KUMAR

THE HINDU VOICE

SUBHASH SHARMA
BJP candidate, Anandpur Sahib

USP: An RSS insider and Punjab BJP vice-president, he is a surprise pick from Anandpur Sahib; is pushing for compensation for militancy-hit Hindu families, upkeep of temples, more avenues for Hindu businessmen

But: The BJP still lacks a strong cadre, especially in Malwa region. Protests by farm unions are limiting its expansion to a few urban pockets

The general election in Punjab is unfolding amid a distinct Hindutva undercurrent stemming from the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya and a counter-movement to the farmers' protests. To accelerate its outreach, both Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah have addressed rallies—marked with the usual Hindu nationalist rhetoric—in the last leg of campaigning. The BJP anticipates that this sentiment will aid its candidates across various constituencies, potentially giving it a bigger slice of the electoral pie. (In 2019, it won two of the three contested seats, with a statewide vote share of 9.6 per cent.) "The Punjabi Hindu is not merely a sentiment," asserts Sharma. "They also hold business interests in the state, yearning for peace, prosperity and favourable opportunities to expand their enterprises and be part of a Viksit Bharat." In his campaign, he has been raising issues like compensation for Hindu families impacted during the militancy era besides highlighting the non-conducive environment for investments.

Similarly, Ravneet Singh Bittu, the three-term Congress MP who pulled a switcheroo and is now the BJP candidate from Ludhiana, is invoking the image of his grandfather, the late Beant Singh, a revered figure among Hindus and moderate Sikhs for his role in crushing militancy during his tenure as CM from 1992 to 1995. In fact, Bittu crossed over to the saffron side soon after the BJP high command shut its doors on the Akali Dal, citing its adamant stance on the demand for the release of convicted Khalistani militants, among them a conspirator behind Beant Singh's assassination in a suicide bombing in 1995. The 'Jai Shri Ram' chants and the campaign song '*Jo Ram Ko Laye Hain, Hum Unko Layenge*'—calling to vote for those who have built the Ram temple—are all the rage at both Sharma's and Bittu's rallies. Like Bittu, Congress turncoat Preneet Kaur (Patiala) and retired diplomat Taranjit Singh Sandhu (Amritsar) are also Sikh Jats with a moderate outlook.

The sentiment is afflicting other parties as well. Even the Akali Dal has fielded two Hindu candidates—N.K. Sharma (Patiala) and Anil Joshi (Amritsar)—while the AAP has given tickets to two Hindu state legislators—Congress turncoat Raj Kumar Chabbewal (Hoshiarpur) and Ashok Prashar Pappi (Ludhiana). Whatever the outcome of the general election on June 4, it is unlikely to put an end to the churn in Punjab's political landscape. Be prepared then for further drama before the state goes to the polls again in 2027. ■